1. Purpose

To mandate a scientifically validated hand hygiene methodology that serves as a primary barrier against the introduction and transmission of pathogens within the food handling environment. By standardizing the mechanical and chemical actions of handwashing, the procedure aims to eliminate transient microbial loads—including enteric viruses and bacterial contaminants—thereby mitigating the risk of cross-contamination between personnel, preparation surfaces, and food products.

2. Scope

To implement strict adherence from every individual—including permanent and contractual employees—who gains access to food-handling or processing environments. By extending these hygiene requirements to all personnel regardless of their role or duration of stay, the facility establishes a rigorous precaution framework designed to eliminate human-vector contamination.

3. Responsibilities

3.1. All Employees

Shall execute the handwashing protocol, bearing the personal responsibility to perform each mechanical scrubbing and rinsing step exactly as prescribed to ensure the total removal of transient pathogens.

3.2. Restaurant Managers

Shall be responsible for the structural integrity of the program; this includes the continuous monitoring of employee compliance to verify that hygiene standards are being upheld in real-time. Furthermore, management must guarantee that all handwashing stations remain fully provisioned with essential supplies—such as antimicrobial soap, single-use paper towels, and potable water—thereby removing any logistical barriers to employee compliance and maintaining the facility and store's overall sanitary defense.

4. Definition of Terms

- **Transient Microbial Loads / Pathogens**: Microorganisms—including enteric viruses and bacterial contaminants—that are temporarily acquired on the skin surface via contact with contaminated objects or environments. These are not deeply anchored and can be mechanically and chemically removed by proper handwashing.
- **Cross-Contamination**: The physical transfer of harmful pathogens or biological contaminants from personnel, contaminated preparation surfaces, or equipment into food products.
- **Human-Vector Contamination**: A specific pathway of contamination where a human being serves as the carrier or vehicle (vector), inadvertently transporting and transferring pathogens into clean or controlled food-handling environments.
- **Biofilm**: A structured, resilient layer of microorganisms that adheres to surfaces (such as plumbing fixtures and sink basins). Biofilms build up when handwashing stations are improperly used for food preparation, utensil rinsing, or disposing of mop water, creating a permanent reservoir for bacterial growth.
- **Critical Control Points (CCPs)**: Mandatory, specific times or operational steps during a shift where employees must immediately perform handwashing to eliminate microbiological hazards before proceeding with work.

- **Double Wash Method**: A specialized two-stage hand hygiene protocol requiring an employee to wash their hands first inside the restroom immediately after use, and then perform a second complete wash at a designated kitchen handwashing station prior to entering the production area.
- **Ready-to-Eat (RTE) Produce**: Food items (such as sliced vegetables or fruits) that are prepared for direct consumption without requiring any subsequent washing, cooking, or thermal processing steps to eliminate pathogens.
- **Food Safety Management System (FSMS)**: The overarching systematic framework of protocols, procedures, and controls implemented by the organization to mitigate food safety risks, maintain strict sanitary defenses, and ensure regulatory compliance.
- **Antimicrobial Soap**: A liquid cleaning agent formulated with active antiseptic ingredients to reduce or destroy transient skin microorganisms. Note: Bar soap is strictly prohibited within this framework as it can harbor bacterial growth.
- **Potable Water**: Clean, running water that meets legal and safety specifications, making it safe for drinking, hand hygiene, and food contact.
- **Contamination**: An officially recognized hygiene breach that occurs when a food handler contacts a high-risk surface (such as waste bins, raw proteins, or personal skin) and subsequently touches food or food-contact surfaces without completing the mandatory handwashing protocol.
- **Adulterated Food**: Food items that have been handled during a recognized hygiene breach or contamination event, rendering them legally impure, unsafe, and unfit for consumption, requiring immediate disposal.

5. Procedure

5.1. Handwashing Method—a six (6) step handwashing method with a 20 second duration.

Step	Action	Description
1	**Wet Hands**	Use clean, running potable water
2	**Apply Soap**	Use a generous amount of liquid antimicrobial soap
3	**Scrub**	Rub hands vigorously for 10 seconds. Scrub backs of hands, wrists, between fingers, and under fingernails
4	**Rinse**	Rinse thoroughly under clean, running water to remove all soap and loosened soil.
5	**Dry**	Use a single-use paper towel or an electric air dryer
6	**Turn Off Tap**	Use a single-use paper towel to turn off the faucet and open the restroom door to avoid re-contaminating clean hands.

5.2. **Critical Control Points**—Employees must wash their hands immediately at these specific times:

- Before starting work or entering the establishment
- After using the restroom (Double Wash Method: Wash in the restroom, then wash again at the station)
- After coughing, sneezing, or using a tissue
- After touching hair, face, or any part of the body
- After handling trash, chemicals, or cleaning tools
- After touching raw produce (especially root vegetables) before handling ready-to-eat (RTE) sliced produce
- After clearing dirty tables and handling used plates/cutlery
- After taking a break or eating
- After taking off soiled gloves, before putting on new ones

6. **Corrective Action—**To maintain the integrity of the Food Safety Management System, the following actions must be taken when handwashing standards are not met:

6.1. **Management Oversight-** The Person in Charge (PIC) or Restaurant Manager is responsible for the continuous monitoring of employee hygiene practices.

- **Immediate Intervention:** Should an employee be observed bypassing a required handwashing step of performing the procedure inadequately, management must intervene immediately.
- **Retraining**: The employee must be removed from the food preparation area and dining area to receive a "just-in-time" training session. This involves a review of the SOP and a demonstration of the correct technique.
- **Validation of Compliance:** The employees may only resume duties once they have successfully demonstrated the 20-second handwashing procedure under direct supervision.

6.2. **Contamination Control**

- Contamination Assessment: If a food handler makes contact with a high-risk surface (e.g. waste receptacles, raw protein, or personal skin) and subsequently touches food or food-contact surfaces without washing, a contamination event if officially recognized.
- Waste Management: Any food items handled during the breach must be deemed adulterated and discarded immediately.
- Sanitization of Surfaces: All affected equipment, utensils, or preparation surfaces must be cleaned and sanitized before production resumes to eliminate any residual microbial load.

7. **Facility Infrastructure and Maintenance**

7.1. **Accessibility and Intended Use**

- **Prohibition of Obstructions:** Stations must remain completely clear of physical barriers, including inventory boxes, mobile equipment, or waste receptacles. Employees must not be required to move any item to reach the sink.
- **Exclusivity of Function:** These sinks are designed strictly for hand hygiene. Using a handwashing station for food preparation, utensil rinsing, or the disposal of mop

water is a severe violation of FSMS protocols, as it introduces a high-risk of contamination and biofilm buildup.

7.2. Mandatory Consumables and Utility Standards— A handwashing station is deemed "non-compliant" if any single component is missing. A proactive replenishment protocol must be enforced to ensure:

- **Cleaning Agents:** Dispensers must be continuously stocked with liquid, antimicrobial soap. The use of bar soap is strictly prohibited as it can serve as a reservoir for bacterial growth.
- **Sanitary Drying Methods:** Stations must be equipped with single-use paper towels in a protected dispenser or high-velocity, HEPA-filtered air dryer. If paper towels are used, a hands-free waste receptacle must be located in the immediate vicinity.

7.3. Standardized Visual Inspection— Signages serves as a critical behavioral "nudge" and a requirement for regulatory auditing

- **Linguistic Inclusivity:** "Wash Hands" notifications must be prominently displayed at eye level. To ensure the FSMS is effective across a diverse workforce, these signs must be printed in the primary languages spoken by all staff members.
- **Instructional Reinforcement:** Beyond simple reminders, stations should feature visual diagrams illustrating the correct 20-second scrubbing technique. This ensures that even under high-pressure service conditions, the procedural standard remains consistent.

8. Verification

This SOP is verified through monthly internal audits and annual reviews of food safety records to ensure the hygiene program remains effective against evolving.

9. Change History

Revision No.:	Revision Date:	Author & Position:	Purpose of Revision
0	February 10, 2026	Marielle Louise Macabale**, QA Specialist**	Originator
1	March 05, 2026	Marielle Louise Macabale**, QA Specialist**	• Change the addressing of personnel; staff members to employees • Remove thermal requirements clause • Added additional signatory; L&D Manager
2	June 2, 2026	Celine Joy Sanchez**, QA Specialist**	• Added Definition of Terms

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